

CHICAGO BOOTH

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT CHICAGO BOOTH

When a business school ranks #1 in The Economist and Forbes, and #4 in the FT, many hundreds of MBA hopefuls will apply to the school in the hope of securing their place in one of the world's best business schools. But Chicago Booth is not for everybody. An integral part of a university that is very clearly focused on research, including the free market theory developed by the famous "Chicago School," Booth thrives on a culture of inquiry and innovation. The Admissions Committee is looking for individuals who like to challenge conventional wisdom and thrive in situations where they take the lead in solving problems.

The MBA program sets itself apart by having a total flexibility in its curriculum. The school assumes that a graduate student knows what he or she is looking for in an MBA and enables students to specialize in the areas that will help them pursue their future business life. This philosophy is a driving force of Chicago as a whole, and extends to the faculty, who are left to choose their pedagogical methodology. Chicago Booth is for students who know where they are going, are ready to go a step further in their chosen discipline, and want to be challenged with the theories and ideas of tomorrow.

STRENGTHS & SPECIALIZATIONS

Finance, Economics, Accounting, Entrepreneurship, Organizational
Behavior, Strategy

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	1	-	3	2	-	4	5	4
Financial Times	6	6	6	6	-	5	4	4
Forbes	-	2	-	6	-	7	-	1
The Economist	1	1	1	1	-	2	1	1
US News	4	6	4	4	-	3	1	3

CLASS OF 2022 ADMISSIONS

Number of Applicants	4909	Avg Age	28
MBA Class Size	621	Avg GMAT	724
Admissions selectivity	25%	Avg GPA	3.6
Yield	50.60%	% International	30%
Total Tuition	US\$146,880	% Women	38%

POST-MBA CAREERS (CLASS OF 2019)

Consulting	38.2%
Financial Services	30.3%
Technology	16.3%
Own business	2.6%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

McKinsey, Bain, Amazon, BCG, JP Morgan, Google, Pwc Strategy&, Accenture, Credit Suisse, Goldman Sachs, Bank of America Corporation, Citigroup, Microsoft, Morgan Stanley, Ernst & Young, PIMCO, Kearney, Facebook, William Blair

AVERAGE BASE SALARY: US\$150,000

EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS: 92.8%

**Rankings are relative to other U.S. business schools. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.*



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR CHICAGO BOOTH APPLICATION

BY JULIE FERGUSON

Julie spent five years at the University of Chicago Booth School of Business, having begun her career in higher education with the Lauder Institute at Wharton. At Chicago Booth, Julie worked as a Senior Associate Director of Admissions. In this role she coordinated admissions and recruiting events across the country, connecting prospective students with current students and alumni; interviewed applicants; and advised the admissions committee.



The academic culture at Chicago Booth encourages innovative thinking, challenging the status quo, and working together to achieve results.

1

WHEN SHOULD YOU APPLY?

Be strategic about which application deadline you will be pursuing. There are three application rounds (September, January, and April) at Chicago Booth, and, as with many other schools, earlier is not necessarily better. The Booth Admissions Committee knows that it will see great profiles in the first and second round, so the school does not need to fill all the places for consultants, bankers and software engineers in round 1, but will use the wait list with discretion to be able to consider everybody applying in round 2. So you are better off waiting for the 2nd round if that means you will have a more complete, well thought out application, or are able to complete a particularly impressive project, secure a promotion, or provide more examples for your recommender to use. The reality is that there are very few places left by round 3, but even then, the Admissions Committee recognizes that there will be a handful of strong candidates applying in the final round for whom places will be available. But the numbers game works against you at this stage, so plan ahead and shoot for September or January to maximize your chances.

HIGHLIGHT YOUR INDIVIDUALITY

2

Every year, hundreds of applications pour in from people with consulting, finance, and accounting backgrounds. Current full-time class statistics show that most students enter the program from a business, economics, and engineering undergraduate background. Chicago Booth looks to create a well- rounded, diverse, and unique class. Make this work in your favor, whether your background is “typical” or not. If you do come from a classic background, tailor your application to highlight what makes you different from everyone else in your industry (perhaps you work as an accountant for a non-profit organization). If, for example, you have a marketing/advertising, education, or social sciences background this will play well into creating a more diverse academic environment for the whole; you will want to emphasize the fact that you will be bringing something unique to the discussion, in and out of the classroom.

3

IT'S NOT ALL ABOUT "ECONOMICS"

There is a common perception that Chicago Booth is the "econ" school. Just like you, Booth does not want to be seen as being good at just one thing. The full-time MBA program provides a flexible curriculum, where students are expected to design their own academic experience. Even if your concentration (your academic interests) lies in economics and the world of finance, you should be well versed on what other academic concentrations are available. Know who the key professors are in each academic department and some of the key published academic research. Familiarize yourself with opportunities outside of your particular interests (such as the New Venture Challenge). The Booth MBA is a transformative experience; through your application, demonstrate to the admissions team that you have a plan, but that you are open to the possibilities and avenues that a Chicago MBA will provide. Show the Committee that you recognize the importance of a well-rounded MBA education, and that you appreciate the value of the flexible curriculum structure.

THE INTERVIEW

4

Chicago Booth extensively uses its network of staff, current students, and alumni to conduct admissions interviews throughout the year, all over the world. Although the interview receives equal weight in the overall application, regardless of who is conducting the interview, you should tailor your interview strategy accordingly. Typically, alumni and current students have a very different perception of how a candidate might fit in at Chicago Booth (using their own personal experience and background), and can often be much more critical evaluators than admissions staff. Admissions staff on the other hand will have a better sense for how the class is already shaping up, and how your unique experience could contribute to the current intake.

Use the interview to highlight areas of your personal and professional life that are not already represented in your application.

Be especially careful of "walking" your interviewer through your resume. They have already looked at your resume, and are looking to glean much more information from you than your professional history timeline. The purpose of the interview is to establish a connection with the person across the table, and convince them of why you are a good "fit" with Chicago Booth.

5

GET TO KNOW BOOTH AND DEFINE HOW YOU WILL BE ABLE TO CONTRIBUTE

The written application is the final piece of the puzzle. There are so many steps that lead up to that “submit” button. Admissions want to know that you are going to be more than a body in a lecture room. Part of what makes Chicago Booth such a thriving academic environment is the diversity of students in each of the MBA programs. This diversity is what drives critical thinking and pushes students into collaboration instead of competition. They want people who will get up and get involved, lead the charge. And beyond the classroom they are looking for engagement and interaction. So do some research on the clubs and activities that would be of interest to you, and where possible reach out to students or alumni who themselves were actively part of a particular club to better understand the opportunities available to you. When possible, you should try to visit campus and/or attend admissions events. It is important to see the programs in action and to see interaction between current students, faculty, and staff. Use all of the information at hand to truly comprehend your “fit” at Chicago Booth and show Admissions not only who you are but what you will contribute to the community as a current student and an alumnus.

ESSAY ANALYSIS

Chicago Booth aims to create a well-rounded, diverse, and unique class, and is looking for individuals who like to challenge conventional wisdom.



ESSAY 1. How will the Booth MBA help you achieve your immediate and long-term post-MBA career goals? (250 word minimum)

Booth's first question cuts to the chase, asking you to connect your compelling and coherent career vision to how the Booth MBA - in particular - positions you to achieve your greatest aspirations. It's a version of an old favorite, 'Why an MBA and why this school' - and significant self-reflection is key to delivering an essay that's both persuasive and sincere. Your ability to articulate clear goals - even if they evolve throughout the MBA journey - show the Admissions Committee your confidence and maturity.

It also requires a deep understanding of Booth's values, culture and what makes it special. Without a nuanced appreciation of its unique community and program offerings - gained by thorough research, thoughtful networking and, whenever possible, a visit to campus - the admissions committee may not see you as a good fit. Acknowledging the specific things that stand out about the school and why they are important to you is key.

Booth is really looking to learn about what skills you have gained in your career thus far and how those will propel you into your MBA program. What specifically about Booth stands out to you? Professors? Classes? Student Organizations? Using your newly minted Booth MBA degree, what are your short and long-term career goals? The important thing here is to clearly identify your long-term goal and describe how your short-term goal will help get you there. You want to create a cohesive story so Booth understands where you've been, where you're going, and how they fit into your story.

What is it you want to do and how is Booth going to get you there? For a question like this, the why behind the goal is as important as the goals themselves.

My Fortuna colleague [Bill Kooser](#), former Chicago Booth Associate Dean, offers this perspective: "I also like to make sure that candidates think of their long term goal in terms of impact - personal, organizational and social/community wide - not just in terms of a position or role. Why is this goal important to you? What led you to it?"

ESSAY 2. An MBA is as much about personal growth as it is about professional development. In addition to sharing your experience and goals in terms of career, we'd like to learn more about you outside of the office. Use this opportunity to tell us something about who you are. (250 word minimum)

The second question is an appeal to share something much more personal, beyond your professional achievements, test scores and transcripts. This essay is new this year, and Booth is mining for a glimpse of who you are above and beyond a shimmering track record of excellence. Booth admissions can glean your professional journey and goals from your resume, letters, and first essay. Now, in this essay, they are looking to find out about what motivates you outside the workplace.

Think of it this way: Similar to [Wharton's MBA essay pairing](#), the first Booth question wants to know what you'll get out of Booth, while the second asks what Booth and its community stands to get out of you. However, it's not quite as direct as Wharton's question. Booth has always been the home of "interesting" students with wide and varied interests. This question seeks to learn what makes you "you" and how that has led to the decisions you've made and the directions you've chosen.

Booth recognizes that we are not linear people and both our work and personal lives inform who we are. Try to focus on an overall theme in your personal life and how that has led to your pursuit of extracurricular activities. Perhaps you had a unique upbringing? Or you have volunteered at a particular organization with a mission that resonates with you? These stories will help color in the areas of your application

and help the admissions committee understand who you are and what makes you tick.

“This is a chance to talk about something that is of real importance to you. It should not only provide an insight into what motivates or interests you, but make the admissions committee say ‘wow’ or ‘interesting!’” says Bill. “The first essay is designed to assess whether you have a well thought out career plan and have a solid sense of what Booth is and does, but it doesn’t provide a lot of opportunity for you to showcase how you are different from other candidates. Essay 2 is your chance to make the admissions committee want to know you better. ”

It can be tricky to know where to start, or intimidating if you think that your story isn’t unique. Start by reflecting on milestones and moments that defined your personal journey and get introspective about what might set you apart from others – even if it doesn’t seem relevant at first.

“You should also think about what gets you most excited, where you spend your time, or what you talk about when you aren’t talking about work. Travel, hobbies, sports? The latest episode of the Queen’s Gambit? Why are those things important to you? How did you get involved?” prompts Bill. “Booth isn’t looking for anything in particular here – they really do want to get to know you. Therefore, if it’s important to you, it will be a relevant topic for your essay. It’s a chance for your personality to shine through and demonstrate that you would be a great addition to what is sure to be an accomplished, diverse, and occasionally quirky class.”

To put a fine point on Bill’s comments, don’t try to anticipate and respond with what you think the Admissions Committee wants to hear. Be yourself and show your enthusiasm – authenticity is essential.

For further essay guidance visit the [Fortuna Blog](#).

DEADLINES & DATES

	APPLICATION DEADLINE	DECISION NOTIFICATION
Round 1	24 September 2020	03 December 2020
Round 2	12 January 2021	18 March 2021
Round 3	01 April 2021	20 May 2021
Chicago Booth Scholars	07 April 2021	3 June 2021



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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